

Learn to Be a Great Communicator: Nonverbals Really Matter, Featuring John Horton

John Horton, Executive Coach

“While you’re listening to someone, don’t just take in the words. Study the speaker. Be aware of the speaker’s voice and mannerisms. Notice his effect on you. Become aware of your own voice and body language, too.” If you need an example of the power of nonverbal communication, simply look no further than Coach Summitt’s own famous stare. The stare was legendary and accompanied by stories from almost every player who played for her and surely every referee who ever blew a whistle against Coach Summitt’s Lady Vols.

In fact, former Lady Vols player Kara Lawson said, “Here’s the thing about the stare, about how powerful it was. You knew when it was on you, when you couldn’t even see it. There were times we would be in the huddle, and I would feel that she was staring at me. And I would say to one of my teammates, ‘She’s looking at me right now, isn’t she?’ And they’d say, ‘Yes, she is.’ You felt it. You felt like wherever you were.”

Albert Mehrabian is professor emeritus of psychology at UCLA. In his foundational work, Dr. Mehrabian and his colleagues studied nonverbal communication in an effort to understand the relative impact of facial expressions and spoken words. Mehrabian’s research provided the basis for a widely quoted and unfortunately, often much oversimplified statistic on the effectiveness of spoken communications. Mehrabian found that 7 percent of a message pertaining to feelings and attitudes is in the words that are spoken. Thirty-eight percent of a message pertaining to feelings and attitudes is paralinguistic, or the way the words are said. And 55 percent of a message pertaining to feelings and attitudes is in facial expression.

The important points of Mehrabian’s work are these: it’s not just the words.

A lot of communication comes through nonverbal communication. Without seeing and hearing nonverbal communication, it’s easier to misunderstand the words. When we’re unsure about what the words mean, we pay more attention to the nonverbal communication.

Pat Summitt found that listening and being aware of her own nonverbal communication made her a better coach. Are you effectively using nonverbal cues and expressions in your own daily communication? As you go about your day for the next few days, be cognizant of how your nonverbal cues help or hurt your communication as a leader.